The Justice G.S. Rajadhyaksha Committee, constituted to study the air transport sector in the country, had reached a similar conclusion. It said: ‘Licensing of too many operators and uneconomic competition among them’ was the main cause for the poor financial state of the airlines.

The chief reasons for the stunted growth of the airline industry were the socialistic policies of Prime Minister Nehru whose government was in favour of the sector being run exclusively by the state. He wrote: ‘As a matter of general policy, we have always thought that transport services of almost all kinds should be State-owned.’ This was, however, a short-sighted policy. The Rajadhyaksha Committee too observed that although the prevailing situation was not healthy, there was no ‘compulsion to take such a serious step as nationalisation’. Ironically, the government took this step though Nehru himself had stated in the Parliament that Air-India had earned international recognition for its exemplary services. He said that the airlines had created a feeling of ‘surprise among the people of international companies in Britian and other places that an Indian international air service had come to succeed because they expected that in view of the highly technical and complicated difficulties which they themselves have experienced any attempt by an Indian company would fail.

The nationalization of the airline ‘grieved’ JRD who had, as he said, ‘devoted so much thought, energy and time [to it] and for the success of which’ he had held ‘high hopes’. The alternatives he suggested to the government, that included a joint private and state ownership, were dismissed. But as a fierce nationalist, he said that his ‘sorrow’ was ‘tempered’ by the thought that during his twenty-one years of ‘endeavour’ to set up the Indian civil aviation sector, the airline had ‘served the country well’.

On Nehru’s request, JRD agreed to stay on as the chairman of Air-India. He held the post until 1978, when the newly elected Janata Party government removed him without even informing him in advance of its decision to replace him. JRD, instead, had to suffer the ignominy of reading of his removal in the newspapers. Ratan was with JRD when he learned about his dismissal. In a recent video, he remembered how distraught his mentor was, saying: ‘Aviation and Air-India in particular were a passionate part of his life and the manner in which it was stripped away left him with a sense of sadness, remorse and perhaps to some extent, bitterness.’